nowhere close to this situation. Even in Asia, the picture is very mixed in respect of compromises and assertions. A comparison of India, China and Japan is interesting in bringing out where these societies have adapted, and where they have held on to their own. While they each offer enough evidence to portray their relationship with the West in easy or difficult terms, the decisive factor has always been the politics of the day.

At every stage of their modernization, these societies have calculated and recalculated their equation with the West. But as Asia makes its influence felt more in the global arena, their national expressions are difficult to keep in check. From limited political assertions, they are moving to broader societal and historical statements. How far these branding exercises will develop and what their impact will be on finding common ground globally is hard to predict.

In dealing with the West, the Chinese often invoke a century of humiliation to justify their positions now. But if anybody should be complaining, it should be India which saw two – not one – centuries of rape and pillaging by Europe. This despoiling of a leading economy of its times is still to be widely appreciated. A 2018 study estimated that the resources drained from India by the UK alone were as much as $ 45 trillion by current value.

The numbers serve to highlight a scale of the looting systematically underplayed by Western narratives. The evidence is there for all to observe, not least the assets with others that have a direct India provenance. Nevertheless, imperialism produced a history accepted in many quarters even today that British rule was somehow beneficial to Indians. The real record, of course, is of creating poverty, opium trade, slavery and famine on a mass scale. Remorse over this dark chapter of history is limited even now. Instead, glorification of this era remains the primary narrative as museums continue to proudly display artefacts that do not belong to them.

Yet, it is remarkable that despite growing consciousness of these depredations, Indians bear little grudge. What has really distinguished India from the China of the 1950-60s or the Japan of the 1930s was that it never resorted to domestic mobilization on the basis of anti-Western sentiment. This largely non-frictional but not always cordial record of ties between the West and India is noteworthy. Once India set history aside and let politics